DR. CELINET DURAN JIMENEZ

State University of New York Oswego

DISMANTLING WHITE SUPREMACY IN THE CLASSROOM AND BEYOND

Abstract

This article examines the ubiquity of white supremacy and its impact on educational environments. White supremacy is an imminent threat to education at all levels; it shapes curricula that further marginalize non-white perspectives and distort historical accuracy. The current paper details the importance of confronting white supremacy in criminal justice education, specifically, as the U.S. criminal legal system is built by and for white supremacy. Criminal justice coursework only benefits from conversations centering race, power, and oppression, as these are the foundations that continue to reverberate throughout law and policy. Through a personalized lens, the author addresses the power of identity and representation in their pedagogical contributions to the field.

Keywords: *White supremacy, Criminal justice education, Higher education, Structural oppression, Diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI)*

DR. CELINET DURAN JIMENEZ

State University of New York Oswego

DISMANTLING WHITE SUPREMACY IN THE CLASSROOM AND BEYOND

Introduction

White supremacy is the greatest threat to education at all levels. As the root cause of all structural and systemic oppression, white supremacy perpetuates racial inequity, marginalizes non-white perspectives, and violently eradicates all opposition to the status quo. The presence of white supremacy in educational curricula not only hinders the academic success of students of color and other marginalized identities, but reinforces harmful narratives about these identities for students with a limited worldview experience. In primary and secondary education, we see white supremacy manifest itself through Eurocentric representations that often omit or misrepresent the contributions and experiences of non-white groups,[1] perpetuating racial biases from a very early age. Even worse, the underrepresentation and lack of acknowledgement of diverse perspectives in educational materials can lead to internalized racism among non-white students, damaging their sense of self and negatively impacting their academic performance.

The effects of white supremacy are even more pronounced and consequential in higher education. Despite their claims of commitment to diversity, equity and inclusion, universities often maintain structures that uphold white dominance.[2] The contradiction between stated values and actual practices creates an environment where students of color face ongoing challenges and hardships similar to, if not worse than, what they experienced in their formative educational years.[3] Confronting white supremacy in higher education is not just an ethical imperative; it is necessary in order to form a truly effective and equitable learning environment. Dismantling white supremacist structures creates a pathway for universities to foster a more inclusive environment where all students benefit and are adequately prepared for an increasingly diverse and globalized world.

One of the most critical areas for addressing white supremacy in higher education is within the curriculum itself. Many academic disciplines, including those in the humanities and social

---

[1] Sandra Stotsky, "Whose Literature? America's!" *Educational Leadership* 49, no. 4 (1991): 53–56; Janine Elizabeth Brown, "*Looking in the Mirror, Looking in the Curriculum: The Perpetuation of Eurocentric Images*" (Masters thesis, University of Toronto, 2007); Marlon Lee Moncrieffe, *Decolonising the History Curriculum: Euro-centrism and Primary Schooling* (Springer Nature, 2020), https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-57945-6.

[2] Carol Schick, "Keeping the Ivory Tower White: Discourses of Racial Domination," *Canadian Journal of Law and Society* 15, no. 2 (2000): 70–90, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0829320100006372; Jessica M. Charbeneau, "Enactments of Whiteness in Pedagogical Practice: Reproducing and Transforming White Hegemony in the University Classroom" (PhD diss., University of Michigan, 2009); Jessica M. Charbeneau, "White Faculty Transforming Whiteness in the Classroom through Pedagogical Practice," *Race Ethnicity and Education* 18, no. 5 (2015): 655–74, https://doi.org/10.1080/13613324.2013.831823.

[3] DeShawn Preston, *Untold Barriers for Black Students in Higher Education: Placing Race at the Center of Developmental Education* (Southern Education Foundation, 2017); Bianca Natalie Ramos, "Moving from Access to Success: How First-Generation Students of Color Can Build Resilience in Higher Education through Mentorship," *The Vermont Connection* 40, no. 1 (2019): 9; Erica J. Lake, "A Case Study of Black Students' Perception of Experiential Learning at PWIs," *National Association of Colleges and Employers*, November 15, 2021, https://www.naceweb.org/diversity-equity-and-inclusion/trends-and-predictions/a-case-study-of-black-students-perception-of-experiential-learning-at-pwis; Lee Jones, ed., *Retaining African Americans in Higher Education: Challenging Paradigms for Retaining Students*, Faculty and Administrators (Taylor & Francis, 2023), https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003446828.

sciences, have historically been shaped by white, Western perspectives.[4] Faculty play a critical role in helping to transform curricula and provide educational content that is transparent, historically accurate and transformative. This process often requires uncomfortable conversations and a willingness to confront one's own biases and positionality. As educators, however, it is our responsibility to confront these issues directly; it does not serve education or the interests of our students to shy away from discomfort, but rather live in it.

As a professor of criminal justice, it is my responsibility to confront white supremacy in all its forms. The discipline is in urgent need of educators who are unwilling to compromise in providing an honest account of the realities of the criminal justice system. Given the inequities and racial disparities embedded in our legal system, it is imperative for students to understand how the American criminal justice system is built by and for white supremacy. Therefore, a responsible criminal justice curriculum critically examines the role of race in crime and punishment. As both a professor and researcher, I center my work in the experiences of non-white and marginalized peoples and how they continue to be targeted and victimized by a system that was built in direct opposition to those interests.

Personal and Professional Interests in White Supremacy

As a woman, an Afro-Latina, immigrant, and first-generation student who was raised in mostly low-income communities, I am personally invested in confronting the perils of white supremacy. I am also a product of the New York City Public School system and have experienced first-hand the intellectual consequences of a white-washed and historically mis-represented education. So much so, that I did not recognize my own Blackness until I was pursuing a Masters in Criminal Justice at Michigan State University.[5] In the classroom, I am very transparent on how my identity informs my research and pedagogy. My research is centered in white supremacy and extremist violence, and I work in a discipline steeped in oppression; as a non-white presenting woman, I cannot disregard the connection between my identity and my work. It is imperative for me that students understand I not only teach from the position as an authority and expert in the field, but from my lived experience as well.

My childhood experiences, both in school and outside of it, shaped the direction of my research and how I view the classroom environment. Growing up in New York City, I was exposed to many identities and cultures, but it also meant I was equally exposed to the harmful effects of prejudice, discrimination, racism, xenophobia and intolerance. My initial interest in domestic terrorism and extremist violence was initially fueled by having witnessed first-hand the terrorist attacks of 9/11. A day that will forever be burned into my memory given the destruction and violence, what was even more disheartening was the immediate backlash toward Muslim and Muslim "perceived" communities. Anti-Muslim hate crime increased exponentially between 2000 and 2001.[6] At the onset of my academic career, my work was focused on confronting and dispelling the xenophobic assumptions about marginalized communities. My work has, therefore, been consistently motivated by the need to push against

---

[4] Kimberlé Williams Crenshaw, ed., *Seeing Race Again: Countering Colorblindness across the Disciplines* (University of California Press, 2019); Hannah Turner, Briony Rogers, Sarah Kneebone, et al., "An Organizing Framework to Break Down Western-Centric Views of Knowledge in North-South Research," *Sustainability Science* 19, no. 2 (2024): 647–64, https://doi.org/10.1007/s11625-024-01478-6.

[5] I recognize the irony of having been raised in Brooklyn for most of life, but it took moving to Michigan to realize I was Black. I am forever thankful to Dr. Louie Rivers for his guidance in this realization.

[6] Human Rights Watch, *September 11th Backlash: Anti-Arab and Anti-Muslim Hate Crimes* (2002), https://www.hrw.org/reports/2002/usahate/usa1102-04.htm.

the status quo and mainstream assumptions of terrorism in the US. The majority of terrorism in the US stems from domestic threats, where less than 10% originates from international actors.[7] (Silva & Duran 2019). Despite the media narratives on the origins and causes of terrorism within the US, domestic terrorists are overwhelmingly white, right-wing and relatively young.[8] (Duran 2021).

The more I progressed through my academic journey, the more frustrated I became with the very obvious gaps in my formative education. As I started teaching, I made it a point to be the kind of professor that would confront the lies of K-12 education. I am committed to providing my students with the entire historical perspective of the inception of the criminal justice system in the US. In my curriculum, my students are not taught about a "broken system", they are taught about a system that operates exactly as it was intended. I make it very clear the importance of understanding how deeply embedded oppression is built into every facet of the criminal justice system – a point that I emphasize across every course that I teach, including more "technical" subjects such as statistics and research methods.

This work is most effective when like-minded individuals are equally invested in dismantling the academic structures that are held up by white supremacy. While one faculty member in one department fighting against the grain is better compared to none, my work is also motivated by others across many disciplines who are committed to disrupting the standards that hinder the academic success of non-white and marginalized peoples. I have always taught from an interdisciplinary approach, as the study of criminal justice itself is a fundamentally multi-layered discipline. I am intentional in addressing multiple academic perspectives, including, but not limited to, anthropology, education, history, literature, political science, psychology, and sociology. Despite working at a PWI (Predominantly White Institution), I am surrounded by colleagues, both faculty and staff, who understand the importance of confronting white supremacy, and do so unapologetically. I am not only grateful for the camaraderie, but find that I am a better researcher, a better educator, and a fundamentally better individual for the opportunity I get in sharing this labor with such fierce advocates.

Finally, my greatest motivation in dismantling white supremacy is in the population we serve: our students. Our institution is relatively close to New York City, so not only do I share a lot of the same identifying characteristics as our marginalized students, I also share similar cultural and educational experiences. It is no secret that the vast majority of college professors are overwhelmingly white and male.[9] My presence in the classroom is itself an attack on white supremacy, particularly as a criminal justice scholar. The importance of increasing representation in higher education, especially in the criminal justice discipline, cannot be overstated. The criminal justice system disproportionately impacts people of color, the indigent, immigrants and other marginalized identities; my position in the classroom not only resonates with students on a personal level, it also lends legitimacy to my curriculum given that I have first-hand knowledge and understanding of students' apprehensions regarding the system. No one is better positioned to educate others on the perils of the oppressive arm of white supremacy than those of us who are directly targeted by it. I strive to bring this level of

---

7

8

9 Sofia P. Baker and Cory Koedel, "Diversity Trends among Faculty in STEM and Non-STEM Fields at Selective Public Universities in the US from 2016 to 2023," *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 11, no. 1 (2024): 1–9, https://doi.org/10.1057/s41599-024-03687-x.

understanding to all facets of my work, and it tends to be favorably received by most of my students.

Centering The Conversation

One of the vast advantages of working in higher education is the autonomy professors receive in preparing for their curricula. I consider myself to be extremely privileged for living in a state that respects and protects the principles of academic freedom, and in my institution I enjoy a lot of latitude in deciding what courses I get to offer and how I teach them. My course offerings are relatively balanced between core requirement courses and electives, which allows me the opportunity to cover a substantial breadth of material. In addition to the core requirement courseload that I have taught over the years (Introduction to Criminal Justice, Crime Theories and Victimization, Research Methods and Statistics), I offer a number of electives that are both culturally relevant and timely (Race and the Criminal Justice System, Extremist Violence in the US, Crime and The Media, Terrorism and Homeland Security, International Criminal Justice and Data Analysis). These courses are not just directly related to my areas of expertise, but are also extremely relevant in combatting white supremacy. Regardless of whether or not I am teaching a core requirement or elective, I am adamant in my stance that a responsible criminal justice curriculum cannot ignore the generational impact of white supremacy, and I center these conversations in everything I do.

In an effort to develop a more equitable and inclusive curriculum, I teach all my classes as a Zero Textbook Cost (ZTC) or Open Education Resources (OER) course. All of my materials are available through open-source and are updated regularly to reflect the most current frameworks. Given the constantly changing nature of the field, I do not believe in relying on dated and/or expensive texts that could serve as a hindrance to my students. Education costs are already astronomical and continue to rise, presenting significant barriers for indigent students. I do not wish to contribute to the levels of gatekeeping that are already built into higher education, and do my best to ensure I maximize students' access to the knowledge they need to be successful. Tuition, already the most significant hardship for students of limited means, and non-tuition costs (i.e. transportation, housing, text-books), can cause students with the greatest financial need to make decisions that are, at times, counter-productive to their educational needs. By creating a ZTC/OER course, I hope students are relieved of additional financial stressors so they can focus better on the learning objectives I've set out for the semester.

Traditional texts reinforce harmful stereotypes and tropes that contribute to the harmful stereotypes and narratives of marginalized others. When reviewing standard criminal justice texts, white males dominate in the imagery of criminal justice personnel or criminal justice actors (i.e. law enforcement, prosecutors, judges, jury images), while people of color are more likely to be depicted as criminals or crime actors. In my experience, textbooks omit and ignore the historical impact of the creation of the US on Native Indigenous populations, and while they are overrepresented in the system, they are underrepresented in texts detailing their experiences with crime, victimization, and other criminal justice processes.[10] More traditional texts do not confront, directly, the leading role of white supremacy in the creation of criminal justice – so I curate texts and resources that are far removed from a traditional criminal justice education.

---

[10] Favian Alejandro Martín, "The Coverage of American Indians and Alaskan Natives in Criminal Justice and Criminology Introductory Textbooks," *Critical Criminology* 22 (2014): 237–56, https://doi.org/10.1007/s10612-013-9216-1.

I believe in an interactive and collaborative classroom where students are allowed autonomy over their learning experience. I routinely check in with my classes for instructional feedback on what is working or what they think could use improvement. This helps me build trust with students and create an environment where they feel invested in learning activities. The conversations we have in class will push students well beyond their comfort zones, and I need for them to know they can trust me to listen to their perspective from their positionality. I make it very clear that I am not there to pass judgement, but to provide guidance and expertise on subjects they either have not thought about or given the room to explore. In an effort to help create stronger connections between the students and the material, I will often share in class how I continue to learn about white supremacy or how I might (or continue to be) complicit in the same white supremacist structures I seek to eliminate. Students find this kind of transparency genuine, and are more likely to respect me and our classroom environment that much more.

As mentioned above, it is important for me that students understand the imperativeness of taking on white supremacy in all disciplines, not just in our classroom. I create the space for students to make connections to other courses (a key aspect to criminal justice considering the interdisciplinary nature of the field), and create larger project assignments that allow students to explore further inquiry and reflect on topics of their choosing. I routinely collaborate with colleagues and offer as much support as I can to amplify their work, while creating the opportunity for them to see how important I view the multifaceted approach of the discipline. For example, it is common for me to offer students extra credit to attend a panel or event featuring my colleagues, while imploring them to consider the connections to what we have covered in class. In a more intentional aspect, I will work directly with colleagues on joint endeavors that amplify the principles of diversity, equity and inclusion. My colleague, and dear friend, Dr. Michael Chaness, who is a faculty member in Anthropology and the Director of the Native American Studies minor, has dedicated himself to amplifying Indigenous voices throughout our campus community. I have encouraged my students and my department to support him with his Red Dress Day installation, an initiative that helps bring awareness to the epidemic of Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women (MMIW). This installation brings students together from across multiple disciplines, including Art and Theater, and they can begin to have conversations on how the educational system in the US is complicit in the erasure of Native Indigenous populations, but particularly how vulnerable Native women are in American society. I am truly grateful for my professional relationship and friendship with Dr. Chaness, as he has been instrumental in helping me understand how my traditional criminal justice education makes me complicit in white supremacy and what I can do to course correct.

I do not subscribe to the notion of hierarchy when it comes to the professor-student relationship. While I understand that I am the expert and the authority in the room, I want my students to view me as someone with whom they can have a real conversation and that I am invested in getting to know how they think. In my Introduction to Criminal Justice course, where I do not know most students, I introduce an icebreaker exercise called “Plead the Fifth”, where students are allowed to ask me whatever they like (within professional boundaries), in an effort for them to get to know me better and creates an opportunity to begin discussing fundamental principles of criminal justice. The conversation usually leads to what led me to pursuing a PhD and remaining in academia, how my journey is similar to or differs from theirs, and how I spend the semester working to help them connect to the material. This activity works best for face-to-face instruction, but has also worked for online instruction as I use a third-party

web-based tool where students can anonymously submit questions. This helps me build trust within the classroom as students see my enthusiasm for the course material.

Given the contemporaneous nature of the criminal justice discipline, I update my in-class discussion topics to reflect current events and issues that are more relatable to what students are experiencing in real-time. While we still cover all the core and foundational principles of the given subject matter, I work to present the information in such a way that students become invested in the material. This technique has served me well in courses that students find more intimidating and are more apprehensive to engage in the material. For example, in Research Method, I find that students view the research process as overwhelming, so I begin the course by walking them through all the ways we casually use research in everyday life. We discuss how we routinely evaluate different social aspects (price comparisons, movie ratings, restaurant reviews), and then slowly transition to the differences between casual observation and empirical research. This helps students get comfortable with applying methodological perspectives in their own work as we progress through the semester. Teaching the more technical courses is a perfect opportunity for us to discuss the explicit and implicit ways white supremacy is embedded into the criminal justice system, even in research. When discussing research methods, I highlight the Tuskegee Syphilis Experiments[11] – this allows students to understand the concept of bias from multiple perspectives. In Data Analysis, I emphasize and demonstrate the ways data can get manipulated to illustrate a false narrative, or how technological tools (e.g. facial recognition) are rooted in prejudice and anti-blackness.

Conclusion

White supremacy poses a significant threat to education at all levels, but particularly within the criminal justice discipline. It perpetuates racism, silences marginalized voices, and undermines the principles of justice and equality we are taught from the foundation of the field. Confronting white supremacy in higher education is not only ethically necessary, but a crucial aspect of curating a truly equitable learning environment for all students. My personal experiences and identity, coupled with my professional expertise, continue to fuel my commitment in dismantling white supremacist structures. Additionally, growing up in low-income communities while navigating a white-washed educational system exposed me first-hand to the negative and harmful impacts of white supremacy across all social institutions.

While individual efforts are important and valuable, confronting and dismantling white supremacy requires a collective and sustained commitment from all members of the academic community. We must recognize and challenge our own biases so that we can transform the educational environment and foster inclusive spaces. If knowledge was not powerful, the oppressive structures in our society would not work so tirelessly to keep us from it. It is through education (an honest and accurate education), that we can adequately prepare students with the skills and critical consciousness necessary to defy oppression and build a better future.

[11] James H. Jones, "The Tuskegee Syphilis Experiment," in *The Oxford Textbook of Clinical Research Ethics*, ed. Ezekiel J. Emanuel et al., 86–96 (Oxford University Press, 2008), https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780195168655.003.0009.